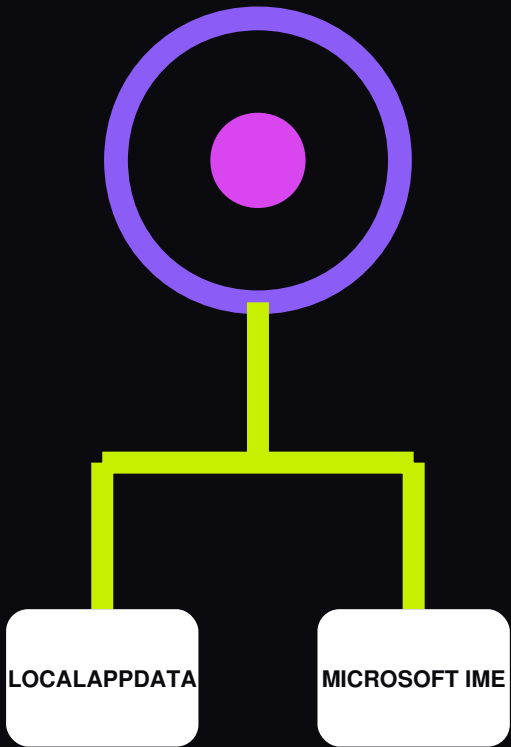


CLEANGULP FILE STAGING IN MICROSOFT IME PATH

Hunts for the source-observed CLEANGULP filename in the Microsoft IME-like LocalAppData directory while preserving file origin and process context for investigation.

HUNTING QUERY

CONFIDENCE: MEDIUM



EVIDENCE BEFORE ALERTING

REPORT DATE	STATUS
25 September 2026	Untested implementation sketch
PRIMARY PLATFORM	OPERATIONAL VALUE
Microsoft Defender XDR	9.7 / 10



EXECUTIVE ASSESSMENT

Decision, confidence and evidence boundary.

ASSESSMENT

OPERATIONAL VALUE

9.7

Hunts for the source-observed CLEANGULP filename in the Microsoft IME-like LocalAppData directory while preserving file origin and process context for investigation.

STATUS

Hunting query

Untested implementation sketch; Confidence Medium.

1primary table

0joins

0secondary rules

2validation gates

Evidence boundary

A result supports investigation of a source-observed path and filename. It does not prove exploitation, file execution, scheduled-task creation, C2 communication, CLEANGULP identity, UTA0565 attribution, or compromise.



BEHAVIOR AND EVIDENCE

Observed facts separated from analytical scope.

MECHANICS

Source-supported fact

- 1 Volexity observed UTA0565 campaigns on 3–4 September 2026 using fake websites and the same Chrome plus Windows zero-day chain previously reported for other actors.
- 2 The final payload, tracked as CLEANGULP, installs to %LOCALAPPDATA%\Microsoft\IME\MicrosoftIME.exe.
- 3 Volexity reports scheduled-task persistence named MicrosoftIME and HTTP C2, but this query observes only the file-system artifact.

Detection hypothesis

If an attacker installs CLEANGULP as observed, DeviceFileEvents should record MicrosoftIME.exe under the Microsoft IME-like LocalAppData directory. Distinction requires publisher, prevalence, ownership, file origin and process lineage.

Unconfirmed elements

A result supports investigation of a source-observed path and filename. It does not prove exploitation, file execution, scheduled-task creation, C2 communication, CLEANGULP identity, UTA0565 attribution, or compromise.

Logic: Campaign-specific artifact **ATT&CK:** T1105 / T1053.005



TELEMETRY CONTRACT

Collection prerequisites and field reliability.

TELEMETRY

REQUIRED

Microsoft Defender for Endpoint file-system telemetry in DeviceFileEvents with FileName and FolderPath populated.

OPTIONAL ENRICHMENT

SHA1 or MD5 when available, signer and prevalence from separate enrichment, file-origin fields, initiating-process lineage, scheduled-task telemetry, network evidence, software ownership and user confirmation.

Fields	Reliability	Use
Timestamp, DeviceId, DeviceName	Documented	Query or triage
ActionType, FileName, FolderPath	Documented	Query or triage
FileSize, SHA1, MD5	Documented; may be empty	Query or triage
FileOriginUrl, FileOriginReferrerUrl, FileOriginIP	Documented; environment-dependent	Query or triage
InitiatingProcessFileName, InitiatingProcessFolderPath	Documented	Query or triage
InitiatingProcessCommandLine, InitiatingProcessUniqueld	Documented	Query or triage
ReportId	Documented; combine with device and time	Query or triage

Excluded

No message body, phishing-page content, inferred success, actor attribution, or undocumented cross-SIEM mapping is used.



PRIMARY KQL

Direct source-supported conditions with investigable output.

HUNTING

STATUS

Hunting query — Untested implementation sketch

KQL — UNTESTED

```
DeviceFileEvents
| where FileName =~ "MicrosoftIME.exe"
| where FolderPath endswith @"\AppData\Local\Microsoft\IME"
| project Timestamp, DeviceId, DeviceName, ActionType,
    FileName, FolderPath, FileSize, SHA1, MD5,
    FileOriginUrl, FileOriginReferrerUrl, FileOriginIP,
    InitiatingProcessFileName, InitiatingProcessFolderPath,
    InitiatingProcessCommandLine, InitiatingProcessUniqueId,
    InitiatingProcessAccountName, InitiatingProcessAccountUpn,
    ReportId
| order by Timestamp desc
```

WINDOW	THRESHOLD	JOIN	EVENT KEY
None	None	None	Device + time + ReportId



TRIAGE AND TUNING

Human validation before response.

WORKFLOW

1

Preserve

Retain the raw file event, full path, hashes, origin fields, process identifiers, device and timestamp.

2

Confirm

Identify the endpoint owner, software publisher, package owner and initiating process.

3

Enrich

SHA1 or MD5 when available, signer and prevalence from separate enrichment, file-origin fields, initiating-process lineage, scheduled-task telemetry, network evidence, software ownership and user confirmation.

4

Scope

Review adjacent process, scheduled-task, file, DNS and network evidence.

Expected benign overlap

Legitimate input-method software, packaging, migration, or enterprise deployment could create the same filename and directory. Confirm publisher, hash prevalence, installation owner, change record, file origin and process lineage; do not allowlist only by filename or domain.

Response boundary

A result supports investigation of a source-observed path and filename. It does not prove exploitation, file execution, scheduled-task creation, C2 communication, CLEANGULP identity, UTA0565 attribution, or compromise.



VALIDATION GATES

Controlled tests and cross-SIEM limits.

QUALITY CONTROL

Validation steps

1. Run the hunt across an agreed historical period and assign every result to a software or endpoint owner.
2. In a lab endpoint, create a benign file at the target path and confirm FileName, FolderPath, ActionType, origin fields and process identifiers are represented as expected.
3. Verify ActionType values in the Defender portal schema reference before adding any action filter.
4. Reject alert deployment if legitimate IME or packaging activity creates unresolved overlap; retain as a campaign hunt.

Decision criteria

Success: The controlled file event is captured with stable path semantics and unexplained matches are sufficiently attributable for analyst review.

Rejection: Legitimate software materially overlaps, the path is not reliably normalized, or differentiation requires mutable hashes, domains, or an arbitrary threshold.

Failure: Defender for Endpoint is absent, DeviceFileEvents coverage is incomplete, the file is installed elsewhere, or the attacker changes the filename or directory.

Platform	Decision	Missing evidence
Defender XDR	Hunting query	Controlled file event and baseline
Splunk	No reliable implementation	Index, sourcetype, parser, sample
Chronicle	No reliable implementation	Parser and exact UDM mapping



CONCLUSION AND REFERENCES

Coverage statement and document control.

FINAL

CONCLUSION

Hunting query

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A result supports investigation of a source-observed path and filename. It does not prove exploitation, file execution, scheduled-task creation, C2 communication, CLEANGULP identity, UTA0565 attribution, or compromise.

MITRE ATT&CK

T1105 / T1053.005

References

1. Volatility — Mind the (Patch) Gap, Part 2 — published 21 Sep 2026; activity observed 3–4 Sep 2026
2. Microsoft — DeviceFileEvents advanced hunting schema — updated 22 Jun 2026; accessed 25 Sep 2026
3. MITRE ATT&CK — T1105 Ingress Tool Transfer; T1053.005 Scheduled Task

Document control

English dossier. No customer data. URLs are defanged in references.txt. HTML and rendering assets remain private.